

5

Personality and Individual Differences



Source: Jeff Chiu/AP/Shutterstock

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this chapter, you should be able to:

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|---|---|
| 5-1 Describe the differences between person–job fit and person–organization fit. | 5-4 Discuss how the concepts of core self-evaluation (CSE), self-monitoring, and proactive personality contribute to the understanding of personality. |
| 5-2 Describe personality, the way it is measured, and the factors that shape it. | 5-5 Describe how the situation affects whether personality predicts behavior. |
| 5-3 Describe the strengths and weaknesses of the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI) personality framework, the Big Five Model, and the Dark Triad. | 5-6 Demonstrate the relevance of intellectual and physical abilities to OB. |
| | 5-7 Contrast terminal and instrumental values. |

Employability Skills Matrix (ESM)

	Myth or Science?	An Ethical Choice	Point/Counterpoint	Toward a Better World	Experiential Exercise	Ethical Dilemma	Case Incident
Critical Thinking & Creativity	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Communication	✓	✓		✓	✓	✓	✓
Collaboration			✓	✓			✓
Self-Management	✓				✓	✓	
Social Responsibility		✓		✓	✓	✓	
Leadership		✓		✓	✓		✓
Career Management			✓		✓	✓	

THE RISE AND FALL OF THERANOS

Many of the best leaders can communicate their vision and inspire people to pursue a common goal. Some of the traits that best predict these behaviors may be essential for effective leadership, such as a charismatic personality. However, traits often associated with influential leadership, including confidence, charisma, and willingness to take risks, are also strongly related to narcissism. Specifically, grandiose narcissists tend to be confident, extroverted, and self-promoting, often helping them assume authority positions in organizations. In extreme cases, narcissism can lead to abuse, exploitation, and ethical misconduct. The question is: How can we tell the difference between a leader who is authentically inspiring people to pursue a common goal and a narcissistic leader with a hidden agenda? The answer is that it can be difficult.

The rise and fall of Theranos provides an excellent example of the interplay between narcissistic personality traits and leadership. Elizabeth Holmes, CEO of the now-defunct company, was once heralded as the next Steve Jobs. At nineteen, she dropped out of Stanford with an ambitious vision to start Theranos, a consumer health care technology startup. At one point, the company was valued at \$9 billion. Holmes achieved this success by convincing many powerful and influential people that her company would revolutionize the health care industry. With just a few drops of blood, the company's technology could supposedly run hundreds of tests. But it turns out Theranos's technology was too good to be true. Holmes and the former president of Theranos, Sunny Balwani, now face federal fraud charges for engaging in schemes to defraud investors, doctors, and patients.

Many now wonder how Holmes could pull off such a large-scale deception and convince so many seemingly intelligent and influential people to believe it. It appears that Holmes's skill for storytelling and her passion allowed her to persuade investors and others to believe in the technology. Holmes would frequently tell others about her uncle, who was diagnosed with skin cancer that rapidly spread, eventually leading to his death. Holmes hoped that her company's blood-testing technology could prevent this from happening to other families. Unfortunately, the case against Holmes shows that she was likely motivated more by fame and money than revolutionizing the health care industry and saving lives.

However, narcissism may not be an entirely negative trait. For example, leadership expert Michael Maccoby believes that there are "productive narcissists," or leaders with a certain degree of narcissism that allows them to achieve their idealistic visions. Maccoby asserts that many respected and influential leaders in history, like the pioneers of the technological revolution Andy Grove, Steve Jobs, and Bill Gates, were productive narcissists. Without this trait, these leaders would lack the confidence to convince others of their abilities and ideas.

On the other hand, some scholars see true narcissistic leaders as damaging to organizations. Field studies have shown that narcissistic CEOs are more likely to engage in fraud and white-collar crime. Furthermore, when in powerful positions, narcissistic CEOs tend to fire or ignore those who challenge them. Charles O'Reilly, a researcher who studies how CEOs' personalities shape organizations, believes there is a key to determining if someone is a productive or destructive narcissist. Organizations often only rely upon interviews and other hiring methods, which a narcissistic leader can easily manipulate. Instead, gathering testimonies or ratings of the leader's personality from individuals who worked with them can be revealing. These other sources of information could ultimately save the organization from a narcissistic leader's potentially disastrous influence.¹

Personality is indeed a strong factor for many life and work outcomes. Personality plays a major role in success in the workplace, although the effects are not always direct; sometimes they are nuanced. We will explain extroversion, conscientiousness, openness, agreeableness, and emotional stability: the traits that comprise the Big Five, the most well-defined and supported personality framework to date. We will also review frameworks that describe an individual's personality and tendencies.

Linking Individuals to the Workplace

5-1 Describe the differences between person-job fit and person-organization fit.

Years ago, organizations were concerned with personality, in part because they used it to match individuals to specific jobs. That concern has expanded to include how well the individual's personality *and* values match the organization.

Why? Because managers today are less interested in an applicant's ability to perform a *specific* job than with the ability to further the organization's mission and to retain the employee (rather than leaving for another organization).² For example, Twegos, a firm that provides a person–organization value fit assessment, assesses truck driver fit with their carrier, trainers, dispatchers, and managers in order to increase engagement and reduce turnover.³ Still, one of the first types of fit managers look for is person–job fit.

Person–Job Fit

The effort to match job requirements with personality characteristics is described by John Holland's **personality–job fit theory**, one of the more proven theories in use internationally.⁴ The Vocational Preference Inventory questionnaire contains 160 occupational titles. Respondents indicate which they like or dislike, and their answers form occupation interest profiles. Holland presented six personality types (see the following section on personality) and proposed that satisfaction and the propensity to leave a position depend on how well individuals match their personalities to a job. Exhibit 5-1 describes the six types, their personality characteristics, and examples of the congruent occupations for each. Notably, this theory tends to be supported with person–job fit strongly predicting job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and intentions to quit.⁵

There are diversity implications for person–job fit that speak to workers' expectations that jobs will be tailored to them. In individualistic countries where workers expect to be heard and respected by management, increasing person–job fit by tailoring the job to the person increases the individual's job satisfaction. However, in collectivistic countries, person–job fit is a weaker predictor of job satisfaction because people do not expect to have a job tailored to them, so they value person–job fit efforts less.⁶ Therefore, managers in collectivistic cultures should not violate cultural norms by designing jobs for individuals; rather, they should seek people who will likely thrive in jobs that have already been structured.⁷ Furthermore, research suggests that giving workers more autonomy in designing their jobs to match their strengths and interests may be more effective for older employees than younger ones. As employees age, they become more aware of their own strengths and interests, meaning that giving them the opportunity to fit the job to their interests, personalities, and strengths can be an effective approach.⁸

personality–job fit theory A theory that identifies six personality types and proposes that the fit between personality type and occupational environment determines satisfaction and turnover.

Exhibit 5-1

Holland's Typology of Personality and Congruent Occupations

Type	Personality Characteristics	Congruent Occupations
<i>Realistic</i> : Prefers physical activities that require skill, strength, and coordination	Shy, genuine, persistent, stable, conforming, practical	Mechanic, drill press operator, assembly-line worker, farmer
<i>Investigative</i> : Prefers activities that involve thinking, organizing, and understanding	Analytical, original, curious, independent	Biologist, economist, mathematician, news reporter
<i>Artistic</i> : Prefers ambiguous and unsystematic activities that allow creative expression	Imaginative, disorderly, idealistic, emotional, impractical	Painter, musician, writer, interior decorator
<i>Social</i> : Prefers activities that involve helping and developing others	Sociable, friendly, cooperative, understanding	Social worker, teacher, counselor, clinical psychologist
<i>Enterprising</i> : Prefers verbal activities in which there are opportunities to influence others and attain power	Self-confident, ambitious, energetic, domineering	Lawyer, real estate agent, public relations specialist, small business manager
<i>Conventional</i> : Prefers rule-regulated, orderly, and unambiguous activities	Conforming, efficient, practical, unimaginative, inflexible	Accountant, corporate manager, bank teller, file clerk

person–organization fit A theory that people are attracted to and selected by organizations that match their values and leave when there is no compatibility.

Person–Organization Fit

We have noted that researchers have looked at matching people to organizations and jobs. If an organization has a dynamic and changing environment and needs employees able to change tasks readily and move easily between teams, it is more important that employees' personalities and individual differences fit with the overall organization's culture than with the characteristics of any specific job.

Person–organization fit essentially means that people are attracted to and are selected by organizations that match their values (discussed later in this chapter) and they leave organizations that are not compatible with them.⁹ For instance, we could expect that extroverts fit well with organizations that value relationships and socialization.¹⁰ Following these guidelines when hiring should yield employees who fit better with the organization, which should, in turn, result in higher employee satisfaction and reduced turnover.¹¹ Research on person–organization fit also looked at whether people's values match the organization's culture (see the chapter on organizational culture and change). A match predicts high job satisfaction and commitment to the organization as well as low turnover.¹² Interestingly, new research suggests that people tend to care more about how well an organization's values would be preferred by the typical person rather than one's own idiosyncratic preferences for values in an organization.¹³ Furthermore, their fit perceptions do not involve comparing themselves to others or logically basing their opinions on how jobs make them feel. Rather, they are relatively automatic judgments that involve both affective reactions and feelings (e.g., attitudes).¹⁴

It is more important than ever for organizations to manage their image online because job seekers view company websites and social media presence as part of their pre-application process.¹⁵ Applicants want to see a user-friendly website or social media page that provides information about company policies, philosophies, and corporate social responsibility (CSR) efforts.¹⁶ These websites are so important to the development of perceived person–organization fit that improvements to their style (usability) and substance (policies) can lead to more applicants.¹⁷ Furthermore, one study examined organizations' or founders' communication on social media and, more specifically, whether they displayed religious values. Applicants who shared the same religious values as the founder or organization were more likely to apply to the job, although most applicants were less likely to apply to the job if the company messaged about its religious values.¹⁸ This study conveys how values communicated via social media can also affect applicant and employee fit perceptions.

Other Dimensions of Fit

Although person–job fit and person–organization fit are considered the most salient dimensions for workplace outcomes, other avenues of fit are worth examining. These include *person–group fit* and *person–supervisor fit*.²⁰ Person–group fit is important in team settings, where the dynamics of team interactions significantly affect work outcomes. Person–supervisor fit has become an important area of research because poor fit in this dimension can lead to lower job satisfaction and reduced performance. There is even some truth to the phrase “misery loves company,” as some research suggests that congruence between leader and follower cynicism predicts follower job performance.²¹

All dimensions of fit are sometimes broadly referred to as person–environment fit. Each dimension can predict work attitudes, which are partially based on culture. A meta-analysis of person–environment fit in East Asia, Europe, and North America suggested that the dimensions of person–organization and person–job fit are the strongest predictors of positive work

Toward a Better World

Uber: In the Median or Back on the Road Again?

When you think about CSR and sustainability, you probably *do not* think about Uber. Instead, you probably think of the appalling press it has received over the years, which prompted the #deleteuber tag circulating on social media. Uber has been burdened with so many scandals that researchers and reporters created timelines, overviews, and even a website to document them. Many have looked to Uber's founder and former CEO, Travis Kalanick, as the potential wellspring for these scandals. Kalanick established a toxic, win-at-all-costs, "tech bro" workplace. In 2017 he was forced to step down as CEO following several scandals, and at the end of 2019 Kalanick stepped down from the board.

Enter Dara Khosrowshahi. The current CEO of Uber has had his work cut out for him. He made it clear that Kalanick would not be involved in the day-to-day running of Uber. He stressed that he would work to clean up the company's image and transform the culture under his leadership. Even the circumstances surrounding the appointment of a new CEO were scandalous. Khosrowshahi was not originally a front-runner in the hiring process. In fact, one firm promised to drop a lawsuit against Uber if it appointed an alternative, favored front-runner as CEO (which many on the board saw as blackmail). This action caused support for this front-runner candidate to switch to Khosrowshahi, ultimately leading him to become CEO.

Years after his appointment, Khosrowshahi led an effort to replace Uber's fourteen corporate values in 2017. The U.S. attorney general and his law firm recommended this action following an investigation of Uber's internal practices. Many believed that the original values encouraged, reinforced, and justified unethical behavior at all organizational levels. These values included vague platitudes like "super-pumpedness," "always be hustling," "toe-stepping," and "champion's mindset" that seemed to encourage conflict and unethical behavior. Khosrowshahi noted that Uber's culture needed to change from one that embraces growth, no matter the cost, toward one that embraces responsible and sustainable growth. To accomplish this, Khosrowshahi elicited submissions of replacement values from more than a thousand employees, which were voted on more than twenty thousand times by employees at the company. He also commissioned twenty workgroups to help define and refine them. The new values are direct and leave little room for interpretation, including: "We do the right thing. Period." "We celebrate differences...ensure people of diverse backgrounds feel welcome." "We value ideas over hierarchy." This approach was interesting because it started with the *people*. Often, when CEOs assume power, they set the values themselves and transmit them from the top down. However, critics have suggested that

changing values on paper is not enough. As Fred Perrotta (CEO of Tortuga) commented, "Your values are what you *live*, not what you *write*." Values in many ways underlie organizational behavior, leading people within organizations to attract, select, and retain people who fit with those values. Therefore, Uber needs to put into practice what it writes on paper.

Although Uber has made steps in the right direction, image is everything. The data shows that Uber is *still* struggling with its reputation and image. Brand sentiment is still low, and it is still struggling to win back customers. However, there are *some* wins to be found. For instance, Uber's current value of diversity and inclusion may have led the company toward its perfect score on the 2020 Corporate Equality Index. Furthermore, Uber has made efforts to establish and continuously improve CSR initiatives. Its competition, Lyft, continues to outshine Uber in its CSR-related communication and messaging, which is incredibly important for reinforcing the values to consumers. It is unclear whether Uber will regain traction or yet again spin out. However, Uber's case makes it abundantly clear that leadership and values play a vital role in CSR. Employees need to be actively engaged to realize CSR goals fully. Employees and managers alike need to recognize that core values become a part of the company's DNA and the DNA of the people who comprise the company.¹⁹

attitudes and performance in North America. These dimensions are important to a lesser degree in Europe, and they are the least important in East Asia.²² Organizational leaders' can manage employees' perceptions of fit, even for jobs that many people do not want (e.g., dirty work), by matching employee individual differences to the job, providing realistic previews of the work and organization, training and socialization to help new employees navigate the job/organization, and providing ongoing support to employees.²³

Person–organization fit is important to Sheila Marcelo, founder and CEO of Care.com, an online sitter and care service. Marcelo seeks to hire employees who share the company's culture of helping others and who are passionate about working on projects that achieve Care.com's mission of improving the lives of families and caregivers.

Source: Kelvin Ma/Bloomberg/Getty Images



5-2 Describe personality, the way it is measured, and the factors that shape it.

Personality

The needs of a business are broad and varied. People are needed to keep track of accounting and finance, to ensure that the right employees are hired and that training needs are met, to market and sell the products or services the company provides, to research and develop better ways of doing things, and so on. Consider this: If every employee you hired was the same and had identical personalities, would they all be equally effective at meeting these needs?²⁴ Before we can answer this question, we need to address a more basic one: What is personality?

What Is Personality?

When we speak of someone's personality, we use many adjectives to describe how they act and seem to think; in one study, participants used 624 distinct adjectives to describe people they knew.²⁵ Thinking of one of your coworkers, you might think they are "fun," "outgoing," "nice," or "hard-working," or maybe you think they are "lazy," "aloof," "close-minded," or "nosy." In organizational behavior (OB), we organize these characteristics into overall traits describing a person's personality.

personality The total number of ways in which an individual reacts to and interacts with the world around them.

Defining Personality For our purposes, think of **personality** as the sum of ways in which an individual reacts to and interacts with the world around them. We most often describe personality in terms of the measurable traits a person exhibits.

Early work on personality tried to identify and label all the enduring characteristics, such as the adjectives you listed previously to describe a coworker, that describe an individual's behavior. When someone frequently exhibits these characteristics across many situations and when they are relatively enduring over time, we call them **personality traits**.²⁶ The more consistent the characteristic over time and the more frequently it occurs in various situations, the more important the trait is in describing the individual.

personality traits Enduring characteristics that describe an individual's behavior.

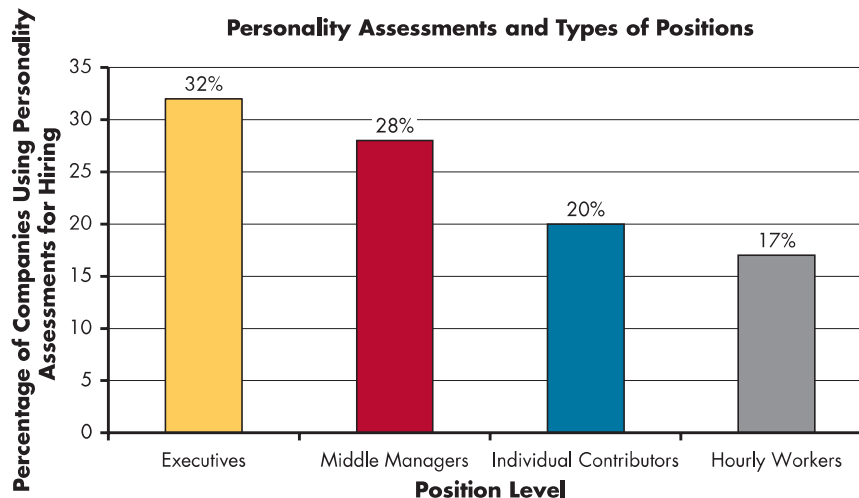
Our culture influences the way we describe ourselves and others. Although many personality traits do tend to emerge across cultures (see the Big Five Model later in this chapter),²⁷ it appears that some traits do not emerge in certain cultures—moreover, certain unique personality traits might emerge.²⁸ For instance, research in Chinese contexts has uncovered unique traits that focus on interpersonal relatedness as well as a relative absence of openness traits.²⁹ As such, when interacting with people from other cultures, it is imperative to keep in mind that there may be cultural differences *even when it comes to personalities*.

Measuring Personality Personality assessments have been increasingly used in diverse organizational settings. In fact, 89 of the Fortune 100 companies and 57 percent of all large U.S. companies use them,³⁰ including Xerox, McDonald's, and Lowe's.³¹ In addition, an estimated 200 federal agencies pay for personality testing as part of their training programs.³² Personality tests are useful in hiring decisions and help managers forecast who is best for a job.³³ Furthermore, you might think that personality tests are really only used to hire middle managers and executives. However, more and more organizations are beginning to use personality tests to hire both full-time and hourly employees (see OB Poll).³⁴

The most common means of measuring personality is through self-report surveys in which individuals evaluate themselves on a series of factors, such as “I worry a lot about the future.”³⁵ In general, when people know their personality scores are going to be used for hiring decisions, they rate themselves much higher on desirable traits (e.g., conscientiousness) than if they are taking the test to learn more about themselves.³⁶ This presents a problem of applicants and candidates “faking” their responses to the personality test, although there are ways to design personality tests to lower the chances this will happen.³⁷ Another problem is accuracy;³⁸ for instance, personality ratings from someone who knows you well (e.g., someone you have worked with for five years) might be more accurate than ratings given by a relative stranger to you.³⁹

OB POLL

Are Personality Assessments Only Used for High-Level Positions?



Source: Based on K. Rockwood, “How Accurate Are Personality Assessments,” *Society for Human Resource Management*, November 21, 2019, <https://www.shrm.org/hr-today/news/hr-magazine/winter2019/pages/how-accurate-are-personality-assessments.aspx>

Observer-ratings surveys provide an independent assessment of personality. Here, a coworker or another observer does the rating. Though the results of self-reports and observer-ratings surveys are strongly correlated, research suggests that observer-ratings surveys predict job success more than self-ratings alone.⁴⁰ However, each can tell us something unique about an individual's behavior, so a combination of self-reports and observer reports predicts performance better than any one type of information. What makes for a good observer? Emotional intelligence (see the chapter on emotions and mood) may play a role here: One study found that accuracy in judging negative versus positive emotional displays played a role in how accurately observers judged emotional stability versus extroversion, respectively.⁴¹

Modern advancements in technology and artificial intelligence (AI) (e.g., machine learning; see introductory chapter) have also improved the ability to score personality tests, reduce faking, and adaptively present items for more accurate personality assessment. For example, machine learning has been used to select the most informative questions for traditional personality tests,⁴² detecting people who fake personality tests,⁴³ measuring personality through the actual language and words people use on social media,⁴⁴ and even scoring job applicants' personal essays!⁴⁵

Personality Frameworks

5-3 Describe the strengths and weaknesses of the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI) personality framework, the Big Five Model, and the Dark Triad.

Throughout history, people have sought to understand what makes individuals behave in different ways. Many of our behaviors stem from our personalities, so understanding the components of personality helps us predict behavior. For example, an employee who is low on tact as a personality trait (a characteristic of “agreeableness”) may be more likely to be rude or direct at inappropriate times, which can in turn upset or anger coworkers.⁴⁶ Theoretical frameworks and assessment tools help us categorize and study these dimensions of personality.

The most widely used and best-known personality frameworks are the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI) and the Big Five Model. Both describe a person's total personality through exploration of the facets of personality. However, the Myers-Briggs has little empirical support for its use, whereas the Big Five is built on a solid foundation of decades of research. (Clearly, evidence-based practitioners and managers would do well to consider the Big Five over the MBTI.) Other frameworks, such as the Dark Triad, explain certain aspects, but not the total, of an individual's personality. We discuss each in the following sections, but let's begin with the dominant frameworks.

The Myers-Briggs Type Indicator

The **Myers-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI)** is the most widely used personality assessment instrument in the world.⁴⁷ It is a one-hundred-question personality test that asks people how they usually feel or act in situations. Respondents are classified as extroverted or introverted (E or I), sensing or intuitive (S or N), thinking or feeling (T or F), and judging or perceiving (J or P):

- *Extroverted (E) versus Introverted (I).* Extroverted individuals are outgoing, sociable, and assertive. Introverts are quiet and shy.
- *Sensing (S) versus Intuitive (N).* Sensing types are practical and prefer routine and order, and they focus on details. Intuitives rely on unconscious processes and look at the big picture.
- *Thinking (T) versus Feeling (F).* Thinking types use reason and logic to handle problems. Feeling types rely on their personal values and emotions.
- *Judging (J) versus Perceiving (P).* Judging types want control and prefer order and structure. Perceiving types are flexible and spontaneous.

Myers-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI) A personality test that taps four characteristics and classifies people into one of sixteen personality types.

The MBTI describes personality types by identifying one trait (e.g., extroversion) from each of the four pairs (e.g., extroversion-introversion) and combining them to form a personality type. For example, Introverted/Intuitive/Thinking/Judging people (INTJs) are visionaries with original minds and great drive. They are skeptical, critical, independent, determined, and often stubborn.

There are a litany of problems with the use of the MBTI.⁴⁸ First, the MBTI was developed in a rather unscientific, subjective way based on Carl Jung's neo-Freudian theories. Although popular and historically influential, very little empirical evidence and research actually support the theory the MBTI is based on. As Professor Ronald Riggio notes, "Jung's theories are not considered to be solid. He wasn't an empiricist. He didn't collect data."⁴⁹ Second, evidence does not support the validity of the MBTI as a measure of personality; in fact, most of the evidence is against it.⁵⁰ As Professor Dan Ariely sardonically noted about MBTI results, "Next time, just look at the horoscope. It is just as valid and takes less time."⁵¹ Third, the MBTI forces a person into one type or another; that is, you are either introverted or extroverted. There is no in-between. Fourth, when people retake the assessment, they often receive different results. An additional problem is in the difficulty of interpretation. There are levels of importance for each of the MBTI facets, and there are separate meanings for certain combinations of facets, all of which require trained interpretation that can leave room for error.

If the MBTI is such a terrible personality measure, why do so many people still use it? In Professor Merve Emre's book on the history of the MBTI, Emre suggests the test is written to be so nonjudgmental that no matter what you select, the results are desirable and appealing. The test also satisfies a desire to know more about yourself in a simple, easy way. As such, the MBTI crafts a very "appealing fantasy" of a coherent understanding of "who you are" and how to maximize your potential using this knowledge.⁵² As a final issue with the MBTI that directly concerns the study of OB, the MBTI does not predict job performance or other important organizational outcomes. Because results tend to be unrelated to job performance, managers should consider using the Big Five Personality Model, discussed next, as the personality selection test for job candidates instead.

The Big Five Personality Model

The MBTI may lack strong supporting evidence, but an impressive body of research supports the **Big Five Model**, which proposes that five basic dimensions encompass most of the differences in human personality.⁵³ Test scores of these traits do a very good job of predicting how people behave in a variety of real-life situations⁵⁴ and remain relatively stable for an individual over time, with some daily variations.⁵⁵ These are the Big Five factors:

- *Conscientiousness.* The **conscientiousness** dimension is a measure of personal consistency and reliability. A highly conscientious person is responsible, organized, dependable, and persistent. Those who score low on this dimension are easily distracted, disorganized, and unreliable.
- *Emotional stability.* The **emotional stability** dimension taps a person's ability to withstand stress. People with emotional stability tend to be calm, self-confident, and secure. High scorers are more likely to be positive and optimistic and experience fewer negative emotions (e.g., nervousness, anxiety, insecurity); they are generally happier than low scorers.
- *Extroversion.* The **extroversion** dimension captures our relational approach toward the social world. Extroverts tend to be gregarious, assertive, and sociable. They experience more positive emotions than do introverts, and they more freely express these feelings. On the other hand, introverts (low extroversion) tend to be more thoughtful, reserved, timid, and quiet.

Big Five Model A personality model that proposes five basic dimensions encompass most of the differences in human personality.

conscientiousness A personality dimension that describes someone who is responsible, dependable, persistent, and organized.

emotional stability A personality dimension that characterizes someone as calm, self-confident, and secure (positive) versus nervous, anxious, and insecure (negative).

extroversion A personality dimension describing someone who is sociable, gregarious, and assertive.

openness to experience A personality dimension that characterizes someone in terms of imagination, artistic sensitivity, and curiosity.

agreeableness A personality dimension that describes someone who is good natured, cooperative, and trusting.

- *Openness to experience.* The **openness to experience** dimension addresses the range of a person's interests and their fascination with novelty. Open people are creative, curious, and artistically sensitive. Those at the low end of the category are conventional and find comfort in the familiar.
- *Agreeableness.* The **agreeableness** dimension refers to an individual's propensity to defer to others. Agreeable people are cooperative, warm, and trusting. You might expect agreeable people to be happier than disagreeable people. They are, but only slightly. When people choose organizational team members, agreeable individuals are usually their first choice. In contrast, people who score low on agreeableness are cold and antagonistic.

How Do the Big Five Traits Predict Behavior at Work? There are many relationships between the Big Five personality dimensions and job performance,⁵⁶ and we are learning more about them every day. Let's explore one trait at a time, beginning with the strongest predictor of job performance—conscientiousness.

Conscientiousness at Work Researchers have stated, “Personal attributes related to conscientiousness... are important for success across many jobs, spanning across low to high levels of job complexity, training, and experience.”⁵⁷ Employees who score higher in conscientiousness develop higher levels of job knowledge, probably because highly conscientious people learn more (conscientiousness may be related to grade point average [GPA]),⁵⁸ and these levels correspond with higher levels of job performance and organizational citizenship behavior (OCB; see the introductory chapter).⁵⁹ Conscientious people are also less likely to engage in counterproductive work behaviors (CWBs),⁶⁰ think less about leaving their organizations, and can adapt to changing task demands and situations.⁶¹ Conscientious people also engage in less unsafe behavior and tend to have fewer accidents than those who are less conscientious.⁶²

General Motors CEO Mary Barra is unusual in that Barra appears to score high on all the Big Five personality dimensions. This unique combination of traits perhaps guided Barra to become the first woman CEO of a major global automaker.

Source: Michael Buholzer/Photoshot/Newscom



Exhibit 5-2
Traits That Matter Most to Business Success at Buyout Companies

Most Important	Less Important
Persistence	Strong oral communication
Attention to detail	Teamwork
Efficiency	Flexibility/adaptability
Analytical skills	Enthusiasm
Setting high standards	Listening skills

Source: Based on S. N. Kaplan, M. M. Klebanov, and M. Sorensen, "Which CEO Characteristics and Abilities Matter?" *The Journal of Finance* 67, no. 3 (2012): 973–1007.

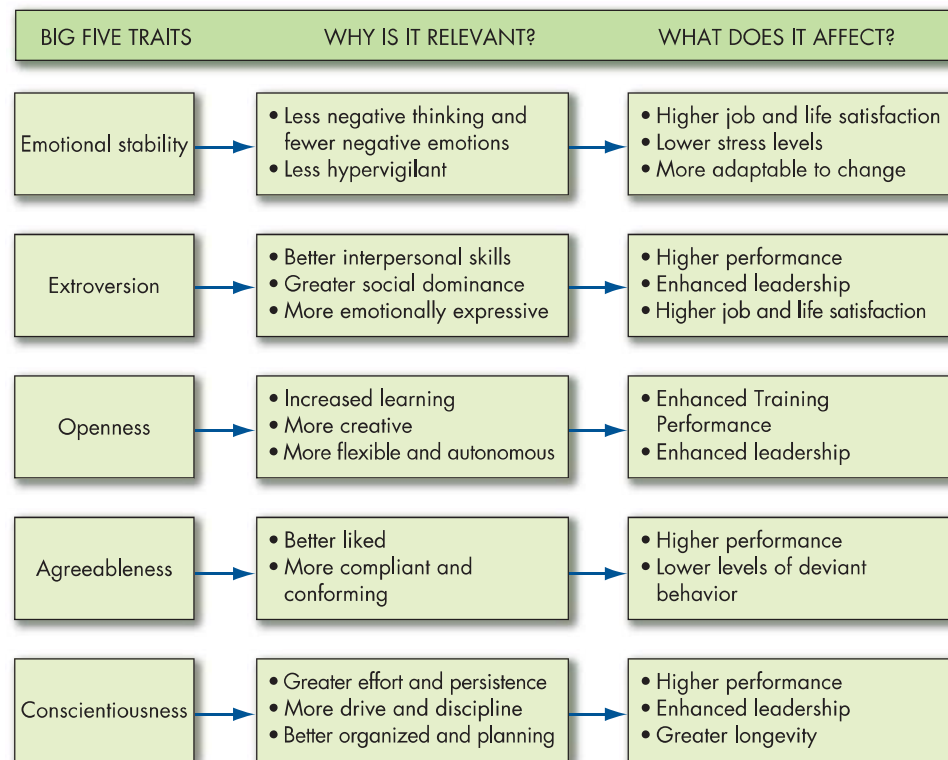
Conscientiousness is important to overall organizational success. As Exhibit 5-2 shows, a study of the personality scores of 313 chief executive officer (CEO) candidates in private equity companies (of whom 225 were hired) found conscientiousness—in the form of persistence, attention to detail, and setting high standards—was more important to success than other traits.⁶³ Like any trait, conscientiousness has pitfalls. Extremely conscientious individuals can be too deliberate and perfectionistic, resulting in diminished happiness and performance, which includes task performance, safety performance, and OCB.⁶⁴ They may also become too focused on their own work to help others in the organization.⁶⁵ Finally, they are often less creative, especially artistically.⁶⁶

Conscientiousness is the best overall predictor of job performance. However, the other Big Five traits are also related to aspects of performance and have other implications for work and for life, as Exhibit 5-3 summarizes.

Emotional Stability at Work Of the Big Five traits, emotional stability is most strongly related to life satisfaction and job satisfaction as well as reduced burnout and intentions to quit.⁶⁷ People with high emotional stability can adapt to unexpected or changing demands in the workplace.⁶⁸ At the other end of the spectrum, individuals with low emotional stability, who may be unable to cope with these demands, may experience burnout.⁶⁹ These people also tend to experience work–family conflict and ostracism, which can affect work outcomes.⁷⁰ Given these straining effects, employees low on emotional stability are more likely to engage in CWBs, less likely to engage in OCBs, and less likely to be motivated at work.⁷¹

Extroversion at Work People with extroverted personality traits experience a small, persistent advantage in their jobs and in their careers. A review of a whopping 97 published meta-analyses strongly supports the “extrovert advantage,” which is primarily due to the positive emotions that extroverts tend to experience (and not primarily due to their adeptness in social interaction, like one might assume).⁷² Extroverts tend to be able to better adapt to career changes (e.g., finding a job after a termination).⁷³ Furthermore, extroverts experience generally high job satisfaction and reduced burnout.⁷⁴ At the group and team level, extroversion is a relatively strong predictor of leadership emergence and behaviors in groups.⁷⁵ However, extroverts can appear to be dominating and are prone to risk-taking, which can be disadvantageous for jobs that do not require frequent social interaction.⁷⁶

Openness at Work Open people tend to be creative and innovative⁷⁷ and are more likely to be effective leaders and more comfortable with ambiguity—they

Exhibit 5-3**Model of How Big Five Traits Influence OB Criteria**

cope better with organizational change and are more adaptable.⁷⁸ While openness is not related to initial performance on a job, individuals higher in openness are less susceptible to a decline in performance over a longer time period.⁷⁹ Open people also experience less work–family conflict.⁸⁰

Agreeableness at Work Agreeable individuals tend to do better in interpersonally oriented jobs such as customer service. They experience less work–family conflict and are less susceptible to turnover.⁸¹ They also engage in a high degree of OCBs⁸² and a low degree of CWBs⁸³ and are less likely to be ostracized by their work groups.⁸⁴ Lastly, agreeableness is associated with lower levels of career success (especially earnings), perhaps because highly agreeable people are less willing to assert themselves.⁸⁵

Interestingly, agreeableness might be more important for organizational commitment (see the chapter on attitudes and job satisfaction) in some cultures. One review of research on nearly twenty thousand employees worldwide found that agreeableness was more predictive of organizational commitment in collectivistic cultures rather than individualistic cultures (see later in this chapter for more information on collectivistic versus individualistic cultures).⁸⁶

Furthermore, given that more companies are sending their employees on global assignments, it is important to understand which other personality traits are most important for adjusting to living in different cultures. Research suggests that extroversion is the most important trait predicting expatriate adjustment, followed by emotional stability and openness.⁸⁷ A study on 2,500 international exchange students worldwide corroborated this, with extroversion

significantly reducing the stress of being in a new culture and improving cultural adaptation.⁸⁸

Research indicates that the Big Five traits have the most verifiable links to important organizational outcomes, but they are not the only traits a person exhibits, nor are they the only ones with OB implications. Let us discuss some other traits, known collectively as the Dark Triad.

The Dark Triad

Outside the Big Five framework, researchers have identified three other socially *undesirable* traits, which we all have in varying degrees: Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy. Owing to their negative nature, researchers have labeled these the **Dark Triad**—though they do not always occur together.⁸⁹ In reviewing these traits, you might remember coworkers or bosses you have had previously who could be characterized by these traits and the consequences these traits had in your workplace. These traits can literally harm an organization's financial performance. For example, one study of 101 hedge fund managers found that those who were narcissistic and psychopathic tended to have worse financial performance than their peers.⁹⁰ These traits might not be as far removed as you think; after all, “not all psychopaths are in prison—some are in the board room.”⁹¹

The Dark Triad may sound sinister, but these traits are not clinical pathologies. They might be expressed particularly strongly when an individual is under stress and unable to moderate any inappropriate responses. Although dark personality traits can have their upsides in certain situations (at least in the short term),⁹² sustained high levels of dark personality traits can cause individuals to derail their careers and personal lives.⁹³

Dark Triad A constellation of negative personality traits consisting of Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy.

Machiavellianism Aiden is a young bank manager in Shanghai. Aiden has received three promotions in the past four years and makes no apologies for using aggressive tactics. “I do whatever I have to do to get ahead,” Aiden says. Aiden would be termed Machiavellian.

The personality characteristic of **Machiavellianism** (often abbreviated *Mach*) is named after Niccolò Machiavelli, who wrote in the sixteenth century about how to gain and use power. An individual high in Machiavellianism is pragmatic, maintains emotional distance, and believes ends can justify means. “If it works, use it” is consistent with a high-Mach perspective. High Machs manipulate more, win more, and are persuaded less by others but persuade others more than do low Machs.⁹⁴ They are more likely to act aggressively and engage in CWBs and, perhaps less obviously, will even engage in OCBs if it is instrumental in acquiring more power or status.⁹⁵ Surprisingly, Machiavellianism does not positively predict overall job performance.⁹⁶ High-Mach employees, by manipulating others to their advantage, win in the short term at a job, but they lose those gains in the long term because they are not well liked.

There are ethical implications for Machiavellians' behavior. High-Mach job seekers were less positively affected by the knowledge that an organization engaged in a high level of CSR,⁹⁷ suggesting that high-Mach people may care less about sustainability issues. Machs' ethical leadership behaviors are also less likely to translate into followers' work engagement because followers see through these behaviors and realize that they are a case of surface acting (see the chapter on emotions and moods).⁹⁸

Machiavellianism The degree to which an individual is pragmatic, maintains emotional distance, and believes that ends can justify means.

Narcissism Avery likes to be the center of attention. Avery thinks of Avery as having a very large number of talents (“See, even ‘a very’ can be found in my name!” Avery says) and having a grandiose and profound influence on others

narcissism The tendency to be arrogant, have a grandiose sense of self-importance, require excessive admiration, and possess a sense of entitlement.

and is very sensitive to criticism. Avery is a narcissist. The trait is named for the Greek myth about Narcissus, a youth so vain and proud he fell in love with his own image. **Narcissism** describes a person who has a grandiose sense of self-importance, requires excessive admiration, and is arrogant. Narcissists often have fantasies of grand success, a tendency to exploit situations and people, a sense of entitlement, and a lack of empathy.⁹⁹ However, narcissists can also be hypersensitive and fragile.¹⁰⁰

While narcissism seems to be relatively unrelated to job effectiveness or OCB (except when it makes them look good),¹⁰¹ it is one of the largest predictors of increased CWB in individualistic cultures—but not in collectivist cultures that discourage self-promotion.¹⁰² Narcissists commonly think they are overqualified for their positions.¹⁰³ When they receive feedback about their performance, they often tune out information that conflicts with their positive self-perception, but they will work harder if rewards are offered.¹⁰⁴ Narcissist managers are even selective about the relationships they form with their subordinates, often prioritizing those who give positive, noncritical feedback (ultimately reducing the voice of all subordinates).¹⁰⁵ Research using data compiled over one hundred years has shown that narcissistic CEOs of baseball organizations generate higher levels of manager turnover, although members of external organizations see them as more influential.¹⁰⁶

On the bright side, narcissists may be more charismatic than others.¹⁰⁷ They are more likely to be chosen for leadership positions, and medium ratings of narcissism (neither extremely high nor extremely low) are positively correlated with leadership effectiveness.¹⁰⁸ Some evidence suggests that narcissists are more adaptable and make better business decisions than others when the issue is complex.¹⁰⁹

Narcissism and its effects are not confined to CEOs or celebrities. Like the effects of Machiavellianism, those of narcissism vary by context but are evident in all areas of life.

psychopathy The tendency for a lack of concern for others and a lack of guilt or remorse when actions cause harm.

Psychopathy Psychopathy is part of the Dark Triad, but in OB, it does not denote clinical mental illness. In the OB context, **psychopathy** is defined as a lack of concern for others and a lack of guilt or remorse when actions cause harm.¹¹⁰ Measures of psychopathy attempt to assess the motivation to comply with social norms; impulsivity; willingness to use deceit to obtain desired ends; and disregard, that is, lack of empathic concern for others.

Research is not consistent about whether psychopathy is important to work behavior. One review found little correlation between measures of psychopathy and job performance or CWBs.¹¹¹ Another found that antisocial personality, which is closely related to psychopathy, was positively related to advancement in the organization but unrelated to other aspects of career success and effectiveness.¹¹² Still other research suggests psychopathy is related to the use of hard influence tactics (threats, manipulation), bullying work behavior (physical or verbal threatening), and inappropriate interpersonal behavior during meetings and suggests that such employees do not feel remorseful for their actions.¹¹³ The cunning displayed by people who score high on psychopathy may thus help them gain power in an organization but keep them from using it toward healthy ends for themselves or their organizations.

Other Frameworks

The Dark Triad is a helpful framework for studying the three dominant dark-side traits in current personality research, and researchers are exploring other traits as well. For instance, the DiSC framework is a circumplex model (similar to the

An Ethical Choice

Do Certain Personality Traits Make You More Unethical?

If one were to ask people if they are ethical, most would say yes. Indeed, evidence suggests that most people, universally and globally, believe in a “true self” that is morally “good” and “just.” Despite this ubiquitous belief, research reveals that, in many ways, people’s (un)ethical behavior can be attributed to differences in personality traits.

These personality traits can be more typical ones that come to mind, such as the facets of the Big Five. For instance, prior research has demonstrated that people low on emotional stability, agreeableness, and conscientiousness are much more prone to engage in unethical behaviors, regardless of whether they are directed toward other individuals or the organization. Some may think of other frameworks as well, including the Dark Triad and honesty traits, which clearly have linkages to (un)ethical behavior. (People who tend to exhibit traits associated with dishonesty, Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychoticism are probably more likely to do unethical things.)

But beyond examining personality traits across contexts, people also have relatively stable aspects of themselves that lead to differences in (un)

ethical behavior. These individual differences comprise what researchers have described as “the moral self.” The concept of the moral self is not a new one—scholars and philosophers have been pondering this question for millennia. For instance, Aristotle proposed that the moral self is a holistic understanding of the self that is grounded in character and virtue. In many ways, character and virtue are related to the values that people espouse and put into practice, another individual difference discussed within this chapter on personality and individual differences.

Modern researchers view the moral self as the degree to which morality and ethicality are important to a person, comprise a central aspect of their identity, and motivate them to behave ethically. These ideas make logical sense—if morality were important to someone, would they be more likely to think through ethical situations and behave in an ethical way? The answer is most likely yes. Another way in which people differ in the moral self is in moral emotions (as discussed in the chapter on emotions and mood). Some people are more prone to experiencing moral emotions; emotions like anger, contempt,

shame, and guilt can drive people to engage in (un)ethical behavior, whereas more callous, nonemotional responses may cause people to disregard the ethical aspects of situations.

Do certain personality traits make people more (un)ethical? In short, yes—certain personality traits can make people more prone to engaging in (un)ethical behaviors. But people do not exist in a vacuum—the strength of the situation and the surrounding context matter to an incredible degree. Moreover, this does not mean that one’s personality forces one to behave in a given way—just that some people may need to work harder to counteract their tendencies than others. So what can one do to come to terms with one’s ethical dispositions and tendencies? Research suggests that self-awareness and self-monitoring are key. Those with confusing or conflicting moral standards, poor impulse control, and a lack of a drive to self-monitor may be more likely to experience ethical lapses. On the other hand, when people establish clear and viable standards, self-monitoring skills, and a drive to change, they may be more likely to counteract their unethical impulses.¹¹⁴

affective circumplex; see the chapter on emotions and mood),¹¹⁵ which suggests that personality characteristics can be represented on a circle with more similar traits in closer proximity, whereas more dissimilar traits are positioned farther apart. Similar to the MBTI,¹¹⁶ people cluster into personality “types” based on their primary characteristic:¹¹⁷ dominating (D), influencing (i), steadiness (S), and conscientiousness (C), although the framework recognizes that “people are not their types.” Despite the DiSC publishers’ claims of validity and reliability evidence¹¹⁸ and its mounting popularity as an alternative to the MBTI, few academic research studies have scientifically examined the validity of the DiSC personality framework. More research and evidence are needed on the DiSC.

One emerging framework incorporates an additional trait into the Big Five framework. The HEXACO model is composed of a new trait, honesty-humility (H), and emotionality (E; i.e., emotional stability), extroversion (X), agreeableness (A), conscientiousness (C), and openness to experience (O).¹¹⁹ The

addition of the H dimension came from cross-cultural studies that suggest that the English-centric early investigations that produced the Big Five essentially “missed” a dimension that began to emerge with studies conducted in non-European cultures (e.g., Korean, Hungarian, etc.).¹²⁰ The H dimension corresponds to people who are sincere, fair, modest, and humble. These individuals are not interested in social status, wealth, or money. Some research suggests that the addition of honesty-humility meaningfully adds to the Big Five, and the honesty-humility dimension has been found to predict ethically relevant outcomes, like abstaining from cheating (even in the presence of temptations or prompts to cheat).¹²¹ This additional dimension has implications for OB, considering that dishonesty and cheating are extremely important for organizations (e.g., employees may cut corners, steal from the organization, etc.).¹²²

Personality traits have both positive and negative aspects. The degree of each trait—those in the Big Five, the Dark Triad, and others—in a person and the combination of traits matter a great deal to organizational outcomes. It would be easy to make quick management decisions based on our observations, but it is important to keep discussions on personality in perspective and to consider other theories.

Other Personality Attributes Relevant to OB

5-4 Discuss how the concepts of core self-evaluation (CSE), self-monitoring, and proactive personality contribute to the understanding of personality.

core self-evaluation (CSE) Bottom-line conclusions individuals have about their capabilities, competence, and worth as a person.

As we have discussed, studies of traits have much to offer to the field of OB. Now we will look at other attributes that are powerful predictors of behavior in organizations: core self-evaluations, self-monitoring, and proactive personality.

Core Self-Evaluations (CSEs)

Core self-evaluations (CSEs) are bottom-line conclusions individuals have about their capabilities, competence, and worth as a person. People who have positive CSEs like themselves and see themselves as effective and in control of their environment. Those with negative CSEs tend to dislike themselves, question their capabilities, and view themselves as powerless over their environment.¹²³ As we discussed in the chapter on job attitudes, CSEs relate to job satisfaction because people who are positive on this trait see more challenge in their jobs and attain more complex jobs.

People with positive CSEs perform better than others because they set more ambitious goals, are more committed to their goals, and persist longer in attempting to reach them.¹²⁴ People who have high CSEs provide better customer service, are more popular coworkers, come up with creative solutions to problems, and may have careers that begin on a better footing and ascend more rapidly over time.¹²⁵ However, high CSEs can have their downsides—for instance, coworkers and supervisors may view those with excessively high CSEs unfavorably, especially if the individual appears to abstain from helping others in the workplace.¹²⁶

CSE also has implications for diversity and employee effectiveness in different cultural contexts. Research also suggests that employees with positive CSEs tend to more effectively adapt to changes in their careers¹²⁷ and to international environments when working in new cultures.¹²⁸ As some examples, one study in a Chinese vehicle manufacturing plant found that CSEs were more positively related to job performance when individualism, rather than collectivism, was valued.¹²⁹ Furthermore, although one’s language proficiency and nationality set employees in multinational teams apart as “different” from the rest of the group, their CSEs compensated for these differentiating factors, and they were able to become better leaders in their teams.¹³⁰



Blake Mycoskie, founder of TOMS Shoes, is confident, capable, and effective. These high core self-evaluations enabled Mycoskie to found a company that uses profits to give shoes to children in need.

Source: Donato Sardella/WireImage/Getty Images

Self-Monitoring

Riley is always in trouble at work. Although Riley is competent, hardworking, and productive, Riley receives average ratings in performance reviews and seems to have made a career out of irritating the supervisors. Riley's problem is one of political ineptness and an inability to adjust to changing situations. As Riley says, "I'm true to myself. I don't remake myself to please others." Riley is a low self-monitor.

Self-monitoring describes an individual's ability to adjust behavior to external, situational factors.¹³¹ High self-monitors show considerable adaptability in adjusting their behavior to external situational factors. They are highly sensitive to external cues and can behave differently in varying situations, sometimes presenting striking contradictions between their public personae and their private selves.¹³² Low self-monitors like Riley cannot disguise themselves in that way. They tend to display their true dispositions and attitudes in every situation; hence, there is high consistency between who they are and what they do.

High self-monitor employees show less commitment to their organizations but receive better performance ratings and are more likely to emerge as leaders.¹³³ High self-monitor managers tend to be more mobile in their careers, receive more promotions (both internal and cross-organizational), and are more likely to occupy central positions in organizations.¹³⁴ However, self-monitoring can be considered a mixed blessing; despite the aforementioned positive benefits, self-monitors may be seen as inauthentic, self-serving, or unprincipled.¹³⁵

self-monitoring A personality trait that measures an individual's ability to adjust their behavior to external, situational factors.

Proactive Personality

Did you ever notice that some people take the initiative to improve their current circumstances or create new ones? These are proactive personalities.¹³⁶ Those with a **proactive personality** identify opportunities, show initiative, take action, and persevere until meaningful change occurs, compared to others who generally react to situations.¹³⁷ For instance, a proactive personality is a key trait that

proactive personality People who identify opportunities, show initiative, take action, and persevere until meaningful change occurs.

Myth or Science?

We Can Accurately Judge Individuals' Personalities a Few Seconds After Meeting Them

Surprisingly, this statement appears to be true.

Research indicates that individuals can accurately appraise others' personalities only a few seconds after first meeting them or sometimes even from a photo. This "zero acquaintance" approach shows that, regardless of the way in which people first meet someone, whether in person or online, their first judgments about the other's personality have some validity. In one study, for example, individuals were asked to introduce themselves in, on average, 7.4 seconds. Observers' ratings of those individuals' extroversion were significantly correlated with the individuals' self-reported extroversion. Other research suggests personalities can be surmised from online profiles at zero acquaintance as well. One study even found that participants could determine the personality traits

of individuals at the ends of the trait spectrum from viewing only photos.

Some traits, such as extroversion, are easier to perceive than others upon initial acquaintance, but less obvious traits like self-esteem are also often judged accurately by others. Even being forced to make intuitive, quick judgments rather than deliberate evaluations does not seem to undermine the accuracy of the appraisals.

Situations make a difference in the accuracy of the judgments for some personality traits. For example, although emotional stability is perhaps the most difficult trait to detect accurately, a recent study found emotional stability could be judged much more accurately when the situation made the individual react nervously. This makes sense when you consider that some situations activate or draw out a trait much more readily than others. Almost

everybody looks calm when they are about to fall asleep!

The moderate accuracy of these "thin slices" (quick inferences from short experiences) helps explain the moderate validity of employment interviews, which we discuss in the human resources chapter. Specifically, research shows that interviewers make up their minds about candidates within two minutes of first meeting them. While this is hardly an ideal way to make important employment decisions, the research on personality shows that these judgments do have some level of validity. It is important to keep in mind, however, that though we can ascertain people's personalities quickly, we should keep an open mind and suspend judgment. There is always more to people than what first meets the eye.¹³⁸

translates entrepreneurs' visions into reality.¹³⁹ Proactive individuals have many desirable behaviors that organizations covet. They have higher levels of job performance¹⁴⁰ and creativity¹⁴¹ and do not need much oversight (and are given more autonomy as a result).¹⁴² They tend to be satisfied with their jobs, committed to their organizations, and engaged in their work¹⁴³ and often achieve career success.¹⁴⁴

A proactive personality may be important for work team members. Teams with high levels of proactive personality among members were more innovative.¹⁴⁵ Proactive team leaders can quickly manage leadership transitions and can more readily build commitment among team members, leading to heightened team performance.¹⁴⁶ Proactive individuals are also more likely to exchange information with others in a team, which builds trust in teammate relationships.¹⁴⁷ However, they are also more likely to be envied by their coworkers and teammates (and prone to social undermining or the withholding of help from others).¹⁴⁸

In short, these personality traits predict many important organizational outcomes. However, there has been a renewed interest in how personality interacts with the environment or how traits are affected by the situation or context. The next section will examine how the work environment, including contexts and situations, affects the expression of personality traits.

Personality and Situations

Some personality traits can be effective in almost any environment or situation. For example, conscientiousness is helpful to the performance of most jobs, and extroversion is related to emergence as a leader in most situations. However, we are learning that the effect of traits on behavior may also depend on the situation. While advancements have been made in terms of mapping the personality domain, similar progress has been made in how people describe *situations*. One impressive study culled 146.7 *billion* words from several different sources that have been used to describe situations. Using AI, these researchers found that situations can be described as positive-negative, complex, typical, important, or humorous.¹⁴⁹ Each of these characteristics can influence behavior or even the “activation” of personality traits.

Two theoretical frameworks, situation strength and trait activation, help describe *how* the context or situations can influence personality and behavior in the workplace.

Situation Strength Theory

Imagine you are in a meeting with your entire office. How likely are you to walk out, shout at a coworker, or turn your back on everyone? Probably highly unlikely. Now imagine you are working from home. You might work in your pajamas, listen to loud music, or shout at your cat walking across your keyboard. From these examples, you can see that many situations vary in their “strength.”

Situation strength theory proposes that the way personality translates into behavior depends on the strength of the situation. By *situation strength*, we mean the degree to which norms, cues, or standards dictate appropriate behavior.¹⁵⁰ Strong situations show us what the right behavior is, pressure us to exhibit it, and discourage the wrong behavior. In weak situations, conversely, “anything goes,” and thus we are freer to express our personality in behavior. Thus, personality traits better predict behavior in weak situations than in strong ones.¹⁵¹

Components of Situation Strength Researchers have analyzed situation strength in organizations in terms of four elements:¹⁵²

1. *Clarity*, or the degree to which cues about work duties and responsibilities are available and clear. Jobs high in clarity produce strong situations because individuals can readily determine what to do. For example, the job of janitor probably provides higher clarity about each task than that of a Hollywood actor’s agent.
2. *Consistency*, or the extent to which cues regarding work duties and responsibilities are compatible with one another. Jobs with high consistency represent strong situations because all the cues point toward the same desired behavior. The job of acute care nurse, for example, probably has higher consistency than the job of manager.
3. *Constraints*, or the extent to which individuals’ freedom to decide or act is limited by forces outside their control. Jobs with many constraints represent strong situations because an individual has limited individual discretion. Bank examiner, for example, is probably a job with stronger constraints than forest ranger.
4. *Consequences*, or the degree to which decisions or actions have important implications for the organization or its members, clients, suppliers, and so on. Jobs with important consequences represent strong situations because the environment is probably heavily structured to guard against mistakes. A surgeon’s job, for example, has higher consequences than a language teacher’s.

5-5

Describe how the situation affects whether personality predicts behavior.

situation strength theory A theory indicating that the way personality translates into behavior depends on the strength of the situation.

Organizational Situations Some researchers have speculated that organizations are strong situations because they impose rules, norms, and standards that govern behavior. These constraints are usually appropriate. For example, we would not want an employee to feel free to engage in sexual harassment, follow questionable accounting procedures, or clock into work only when the mood strikes.

Beyond the basics, though, it is not always desirable for organizations to create strong situations for their employees for several reasons. The elements of situation strength are often determined by organization rules and guidelines, which adds some objectivity to them. However, the perception of these rules influences how the person will respond to the situation's strength.¹⁵³ For instance, a construction supervisor who prioritizes safety will create a strong situation by establishing compelling norms for safety behavior. In turn, this situation may reduce accidents and injuries because it (1) promotes safety behaviors and (2) provides less of an opportunity for workers' personality to influence their behavior. In other words, employees with more careless or lackadaisical traits (e.g., low in conscientiousness) may be urged to comply with norms or risk being fired—so they follow the norms, perhaps begrudgingly. In general, their attitudes and behavior are a function of the strength of the situation.¹⁵⁴ Second, jobs with myriad rules and tightly controlled processes can be dull or demotivating. Imagine that all work was executed with an assembly-line approach. Some people may prefer the routine, but many prefer having some variety and freedom. Third, strong situations might suppress the innovation prized by some organizations or that is needed to be successful in creative occupations.

Interestingly, when organizations tightly control processes that demotivate, suppress innovation, or block employees' preferred way of doing things, sometimes *other* personality traits will shine through even though the situation is strong.¹⁵⁵ As an example, say your supervisor establishes a policy to stop you and your coworkers from accomplishing a task using a very easy method. Now, your job has become harder and limited the extent to which your conscientiousness can “shine through.” In response, another trait might come through despite the situations' strength. For example, now your disagreeableness might lead you to engage in CWBs, like purposefully ignoring the policy or shirking your responsibilities because you are angry about the policy change and the strong situation.

In sum, managers need to recognize the role of situation strength in the workplace and find the appropriate balance.

Trait Activation Theory

Another important theoretical framework toward understanding personality and situations is **trait activation theory (TAT)**. TAT predicts that some situations, events, or interventions “activate” a trait more than others. Using TAT, we can foresee which jobs suit certain personalities. For example, a commission-based compensation plan would likely activate extroversion because extroverted people are more reward-sensitive, than, say, open people. Conversely, in jobs that encourage creativity, differences in openness may better predict desired behavior than differences in extroversion. See Exhibit 5-4 for specific examples.

TAT also applies to personality tendencies. For example, people learning online respond differently when their behavior is being electronically monitored. Those who had a high fear of failure had higher apprehension from the monitoring than others and learned significantly less. In this case, a feature of the environment (electronic monitoring) activated a trait (fear of failing), and the combination of the two meant lowered job performance.¹⁵⁶ TAT can also work in a positive way. One study found that when your coworkers are supportive, conscientious personality traits are activated so that you have a stronger sense of duty toward your fellow coworkers and, in turn, are more likely to share information with them when conflicted about whether to do so.¹⁵⁷

trait activation theory (TAT) A theory that predicts that some situations, events, or interventions “activate” a trait more than others.

Exhibit 5-4 Trait Activation Theory: Jobs in Which Certain Big Five Traits Are More Relevant

Detail Orientation Required	Social Skills Required	Competitive Work	Innovation Required	Dealing with Angry People	Time Pressure (Deadlines)
Jobs scoring high (the traits listed here should predict behavior in these jobs)					
Air traffic controller	Clergy	Coach/scout	Actor	Correctional officer	Broadcast news analyst
Accountant	Therapist	Financial manager	Systems analyst	Telemarketer	Editor
Legal secretary	Concierge	Sales representative	Advertising writer	Flight attendant	Airline pilot
Jobs scoring low (the traits listed here should not predict behavior in these jobs)					
Forester	Software engineer	Postal clerk	Court reporter	Composer	Skincare specialist
Masseuse	Pump operator	Historian	Archivist	Biologist	Mathematician
Model	Broadcast technician	Nuclear reactor operator	Medical technician	Statistician	Fitness trainer
Jobs that score high activate these traits (make them more relevant to predicting behavior)					
Conscientiousness (+)	Extroversion (+) Agreeableness (+)	Extroversion (+) Agreeableness (–)	Openness (+)	Extroversion (+) Agreeableness (+) Emotional Stability (+)	Conscientiousness (+) Emotional Stability (+)

Note: A plus (+) sign means that individuals who score high on this trait should do better in this job. A minus (–) sign means that individuals who score low on this trait should do better in this job.

Together, situation strength and trait activation theories show that the classic debate over nature versus nurture might best be framed as nature *and* nurture. Not only does each affect behavior, but they interact with one another. Put another way, personality and the situation both affect work behavior, but when the situation is right, the power of personality to predict behavior is even higher.¹⁵⁸ In the next sections, we move beyond a discussion of personality toward two other important individual differences for OB: ability and values.

Ability

Regardless of how motivated you are, you may not be able to act as well as Denzel Washington, vault as well as Simone Biles, or write as well as Amanda Gorman. Of course, all of us have strengths and weaknesses that make us relatively superior or inferior to others in performing certain tasks or activities. From management's standpoint, the challenge is to understand the differences and thus increase the likelihood that a given employee will perform the job well. Applicants and employees, then, should market their abilities and develop skills to be successful in the jobs they want.

What does *ability* mean? As we use the term, **ability** is an individual's current capacity to perform the various tasks in a job. Overall abilities are essentially made up of two sets of factors: intellectual and physical.

5-6 Demonstrate the relevance of intellectual and physical abilities to OB.

ability An individual's capacity to perform the various tasks in a job.

Intellectual Abilities

Intellectual abilities are abilities needed to perform mental activities—thinking, reasoning, and problem solving. Most societies place a high value on intelligence, and for good reason. Smart people are generally better performers, earn more money, are promoted more often, and attain higher-level jobs.¹⁵⁹ Jobs differ in the demands they place on intellectual abilities. Research consistently indicates a correspondence between ability and job performance, especially for complex jobs and tasks. Where employee tasks are highly routine and there are few or no opportunities to exercise discretion, a high intelligence quotient (IQ)

intellectual abilities The capacity to do mental activities—thinking, reasoning, and problem solving.

is not as important to performing well.¹⁶⁰ While intelligence (especially when combined with motivation, discussed later in the text)¹⁶¹ is a huge benefit to performing a job well, it does not make people happier or more satisfied with their jobs.¹⁶² In fact, research suggests that those with higher cognitive ability and who are high performers in the workplace might be victimized, bullied, and mistreated by their peers due to envy and social comparison.¹⁶³

Assessing and measuring intellectual ability are not always simple, partially because people are not consistently capable of correctly assessing their own intellectual abilities.¹⁶⁴ IQ tests are designed to ascertain a person’s general intellectual abilities, but the origins, influence factors, and testing of (IQ) are controversial.¹⁶⁵ So, too, are popular college admission tests, such as the SAT and ACT, and graduate admission tests in business (GMAT), law (LSAT), and medicine (MCAT). The firms that produce these tests do not claim that they assess intelligence, but experts confirm that they do.¹⁶⁶ Many organizations use intelligence tests in hiring decisions; for example, if you want to be a professional football player in the NFL, you will have to take an intellectual abilities test!¹⁶⁷

Dimensions of Intellectual Ability The seven most frequently cited dimensions making up intellectual ability are number aptitude, verbal comprehension, perceptual speed, inductive reasoning, deductive reasoning, spatial visualization, and memory.¹⁶⁸ Exhibit 5-5 describes these dimensions. These dimensions are positively correlated, so if you score high on verbal comprehension, for example, you are also more likely to score high on spatial visualization. The correlations are high enough that researchers also recognize that intelligence takes on an overall, global form as **general mental ability (GMA)**.¹⁶⁹

Evidence supports the idea that the structures and measures of intellectual abilities generalize across cultures: GMA was found in 73.2 percent of countries in one study of more than 50,000 individuals.¹⁷⁰ Someone in Venezuela or Sudan, for instance, does not have a different set of mental abilities than an American or Czech individual. There is some evidence that IQ scores vary to

general mental ability (GMA) An overall factor of intelligence, as suggested by the positive correlations among specific intellectual ability dimensions.

Exhibit 5-5 Dimensions of Intellectual Ability		
Dimension	Description	Job Example
Number aptitude	Ability to do speedy and accurate arithmetic	Accountant: Computing the sales tax on a set of items
Verbal comprehension	Ability to understand what is read or heard and the relationship of words to each other	Plant manager: Following corporate policies on hiring
Perceptual speed	Ability to identify visual similarities and differences quickly and accurately	Fire investigator: Identifying clues to support a charge of arson
Inductive reasoning	Ability to identify a logical sequence in a problem and then solve the problem	Market researcher: Forecasting demand for a product in the next time period
Deductive reasoning	Ability to use logic and assess the implications of an argument	Supervisor: Choosing between two different suggestions offered by employees
Spatial visualization	Ability to imagine how an object would look if its position in space were changed	Interior decorator: Redecorating an office
Memory	Ability to retain and recall past experiences	Salesperson: Remembering the names of customers

some degree across cultures, but this gap is decreasing year by year, and those differences become much smaller when we consider educational and economic differences.¹⁷¹

The Wonderlic Ability Test It might surprise you that the intelligence test most widely used in hiring decisions, the Wonderlic Ability Test, takes only twelve minutes to complete. There are different forms of the test, but each has fifty questions and the same general construct. Here are two questions to try:

- When rope is selling at \$0.10 a foot, how many feet can you buy for \$0.60?
- Assume the first two statements below are true. Is the final one true, false, or not certain?
 - a. The boy plays baseball.
 - b. All baseball players wear hats.
 - c. The boy wears a hat.

The Wonderlic measures both speed (almost nobody has time to answer every question) and power (the questions get harder as you go along), so the average score is quite low—about twenty-one out of fifty. Because the Wonderlic can provide valid information cheaply, many organizations use it in hiring decisions, including Aveda, Duracell, Subway, and U-Haul.¹⁷² Most of these companies do not give up other hiring tools, such as application forms or interviews. Rather, they add the Wonderlic for its ability to provide valid data on applicants' intelligence levels.

Regardless of the test used, evidence suggests that using intellectual abilities tests in hiring or other HR practices may lead to disparate impact in organizations (see the chapter on diversity).¹⁷³ Managers should exercise caution in implementing intellectual ability tests for HR purposes (e.g., hiring) and should actively monitor whether the test is excluding members from underrepresented groups or protected classes.

Physical Abilities

Though the changing nature of work suggests that intellectual abilities are increasingly important for many jobs, **physical abilities** have been and will remain valuable. Research on hundreds of jobs has identified nine basic abilities needed in the performance of physical tasks.¹⁷⁴ These are described in Exhibit 5-6. High employee performance is likely to be achieved when the extent to which a job requires each of the nine abilities matches the abilities of employees in that job.¹⁷⁵ For example, certain occupations might require more strength than others (e.g., firefighting); as such, measures of physical ability predict long-term firefighter performance in these occupations.¹⁷⁶ Problems with discrimination can occur, however, when using physical abilities tests, as men tend to score substantially better than women on these tests. To some degree, one can improve the extent to which women meet minimum qualifications through physical fitness training.¹⁷⁷ If a job you are seeking employment in requires strength, flexibility, or other physical requirements, it might be best to train to ensure you are sufficiently prepared.

In sum, ability-related individual differences are important in a number of types of jobs and occupations (e.g., jobs that require complex tasks or physical prowess). At the same time, organizations are increasingly aware that an optimally productive workforce includes all types of people and does not automatically exclude anyone based on broad categories of abilities. Managers should be careful using ability measures for HR purposes unless the ability measured is absolutely required for the job. Of course,

physical abilities The capacity to do tasks that demand stamina, dexterity, strength, and similar characteristics.

Exhibit 5-6
Nine Basic Physical Abilities

Strength Factors	
1. Dynamic strength	Ability to exert muscular force repeatedly or continuously over time
2. Trunk strength	Ability to exert muscular strength using the trunk (particularly abdominal) muscles
3. Static strength	Ability to exert force against external objects
4. Explosive strength	Ability to expend a maximum of energy in one or a series of explosive acts
Flexibility Factors	
5. Extent flexibility	Ability to move the trunk and back muscles as far as possible
6. Dynamic flexibility	Ability to make rapid, repeated flexing movements
Other Factors	
7. Body coordination	Ability to coordinate the simultaneous actions of different parts of the body
8. Balance	Ability to maintain equilibrium despite forces pulling off balance
9. Stamina	Ability to continue maximum effort requiring prolonged effort over time

simultaneously aspiring toward diversity yet realizing the predictive benefits of individual differences assessments takes skill and should be a part of any organization’s diversity management strategies (see the chapter on diversity).

Having discussed abilities as an individual difference, we now turn to values. Values are often very specific and describe belief systems rather than behavioral tendencies. Some beliefs or values reflect a person’s cultural background (see the chapter on diversity for an in-depth explanation), whereas other values reflect personality. However, as we will learn in the next section, we do not always act consistently with our values.

Values

5-7
Contrast terminal and instrumental values.

values Basic convictions that some actions and outcomes are more morally, socially, or personally preferable than others.

value system A hierarchy based on a ranking of an individual’s values in terms of their intensity.

At the heart of all organizations lie a set of values that are central to their mission. Wells Fargo, for instance, values “what’s right for customers” and states that it places “customers at the center of everything we do. We want to exceed customer expectations and build relationships that last a lifetime.”¹⁷⁸ However, sometimes the values or behaviors of the people who make up organizations do not match the values they espouse. For example, employees of Wells Fargo, the same organization that values “what’s right for customers,” opened millions of fake accounts, moved money into these accounts, and signed customers up for online banking without their consent to meet sales goals—opening the company up to legal troubles.¹⁷⁹

Values represent relatively stable and enduring,¹⁸⁰ basic convictions that some actions and outcomes are more morally, socially, or personally preferable than others.¹⁸¹ Values contain a judgmental element because they carry an individual’s ideas about what is right, good, or desirable. They have both content and intensity attributes. The content attribute says a mode of conduct or end-state of existence is *important*. The intensity attribute specifies *how important* it is. When a person ranks their values in terms of intensity, we get an idea of that person’s **value system**. We all have a hierarchy of values according to the relative importance we assign to values such as freedom, pleasure, self-respect, honesty, obedience, and equality. Values lay the foundation for understanding attitudes and motivation, and they influence our perceptions. We enter an organization with preconceived notions of what “ought” and “ought not” to be. These notions contain our interpretations of right and

wrong and our preferences for certain behaviors or outcomes. Regardless of whether they clarify or bias our judgment, our values influence our attitudes and behaviors at work.

Many of the values we hold are established in our early years—by parents, teachers, friends, and others.¹⁸² If we question our values, they may change, but more often they are reinforced. There is also evidence linking personality to values, implying our values may be partly determined by our personality traits.¹⁸³ Open people, for example, value pursuing new ideas (e.g., trying a new sales strategy rather than exercising restraint), while agreeable people may place a greater value on caring for others and cooperating (e.g., being attracted to a collaborative rather than competitive work environment).¹⁸⁴

While values can sometimes augment decision making, at times they can cloud objectivity and rationality.¹⁸⁵ Suppose you enter an organization with the view that allocating pay based on performance is right while allocating pay based on seniority is wrong. How will you react if you find the organization you have just joined rewards seniority and not performance? You are likely to be disappointed—this can lead to job dissatisfaction and a decision not to exert a high level of effort because “It’s probably not going to lead to more money anyway.” Would your attitudes and behavior be different if your values aligned with the organization’s pay policies? Most likely.

Terminal Versus Instrumental Values

How can we organize values? One researcher—Milton Rokeach—argued that we can separate them into two categories.¹⁸⁶ One set, called **terminal values**, refers to desirable end-states. These are the goals a person would like to achieve during a lifetime. The other set, called **instrumental values**, refers to preferable modes of behavior, or means of achieving the terminal values. Some examples of terminal values are prosperity and economic success, freedom, health and well-being, world peace, and meaning in life. Examples of instrumental values are autonomy and self-reliance, personal discipline, kindness, and goal-orientation. Each of us places value on both the ends (terminal values) and the means (instrumental values).

Building upon Rokeach’s value theory, Shalom Schwartz organized Rokeach’s values into ten dimensions: achievement, hedonism, stimulation, self-direction, universalism, benevolence, tradition, conformity, security, and power.¹⁸⁷ Schwartz provided evidence across twenty separate countries for this framework of values.¹⁸⁸ Perhaps it is easy to see how some of these values are directly relevant to people in organizations, with some (e.g., universalism, benevolence, etc.) promoting effectiveness and treating others well, while others can cling to what is typically done (e.g., tradition, conformity, and security) or value self-enhancement (e.g., power and achievement). Perhaps Wells Fargo, although valuing benevolence toward customers, was composed of employees who personally valued self-enhancement.

terminal values Desirable end-states of existence; the goals a person would like to achieve during their lifetime.

instrumental values Preferable modes of behavior or means of achieving one’s terminal values.

Generational Values

Researchers have integrated several analyses of work values into groups that attempt to capture the shared views of different cohorts or generations in the U.S. workforce.¹⁸⁹ You will surely be familiar with the labels—for example, baby boomers, Gen Xers, millennials, Gen Zers—some of which are used internationally. Exhibit 5-7 segments employees by the era during which they entered the workforce.¹⁹⁰

Though it is fascinating to think about generational values, remember that these classifications lack solid research support. Early research was plagued by methodological problems that made it difficult to assess whether differences exist. Reviews suggest many of the generalizations are either overblown or incorrect.¹⁹¹ Differences across generations often do not support popular conceptions of how generations differ. For example, the value placed on leisure has increased over generations from the baby boomers to the millennials, and work centrality has declined, but research did not find that millennials had more altruistic work values.¹⁹² Also, research has failed to support that baby boomers have a higher work ethic than other generations.¹⁹³ Another modern criticism of millennials is that they are entitled and remnants of the “participation trophy” generation;¹⁹⁴ however, one study of more than ten thousand people suggests that there are no differences between generations in entitlement. Furthermore, generational research criticisms aside, this study suggested that baby boomers are the ones who tend to become more entitled as they age!¹⁹⁵

Another study tried to uncover whether major events (e.g., the Social Reform era in China) influenced the values of later generations.¹⁹⁶ If generational differences are real, one would expect major, value-defining events to lead to changes in generational values over time for the affected generation. In this study, generational values were largely similar before, during, and after China’s Social Reform. Interestingly, *all generations* experienced increasing openness to change as a result of the Reform.¹⁹⁷ As such, perhaps major events do not affect specific generations, as many claim (e.g., the Vietnam War’s influence on boomers, the dot-com boom on Gen Xers, the Great Recession on millennials). Instead, maybe these events affect all people who were alive at the time in similar ways.

Despite the lack of support for the validity of generational values, support has been provided for differences in how people *perceive* those of other generations—in the workplace, people place others into generational categories and apply stereotypes that affect workplace decisions.¹⁹⁸ Although there is little validity to generational differences, nevertheless, these differences are still perpetuated as stereotypes that are often applied in the workplace, which can result in ageist or discriminatory climates (see the chapter on diversity) if left unchecked.¹⁹⁹

Exhibit 5-7 Dominant Generational Work Values in Today’s Workforce			
Generational Cohort	Born	Entered the Workforce	Dominant Work Values
Baby Boomers	1946–1964	1961–1979	Optimism, Competition, Hard Work, Teamwork, Loyalty, Duty
Generation Xers	1965–1980	1980–1995	Flexibility, Informality, Skepticism, Independence, Diversity, Work-Life Balance, Self-Enhancement
Millennials	1981–2000	1996–2015	Competition, Open-mindedness, Achievement, Responsibility, Uniqueness, Quality Relationships
Generation Zers	2001–2020	2015 to present	Multiculturalism, Diversity, Entrepreneurship, Progressiveness, Ambidexterity, Personalization, Individuality, Creativity, and Innovation

Source: Based on Purdue Global, *Generational Differences in the Workplace*, accessed February 18, 2021, <https://www.purdueglobal.edu/education-partnerships/generational-workforce-differences-infographic/>

Summary

Personality and individual differences matter to organizational behavior. They are critically important because the fit between people and their jobs, organizations, supervisors, and groups affects employee job attitudes, performance, and intentions to quit. In this chapter, we discussed personality and two individual differences highly relevant to OB (e.g., abilities and values). The Big Five has been a significant advancement, though the Dark Triad and other traits (i.e., proactive personality) matter as well. Emerging theory and research reveal how personality matters more in some situations than others. Every trait and individual difference has advantages and disadvantages for work attitudes and behavior. There is no perfect constellation of characteristics that is ideal in every situation. Personality and individual differences can help you understand why people (including yourself!) act, think, and feel the way they do. Astute managers and employees can put that understanding to use by placing themselves (and assisting others in placing themselves) in situations that best fit their personalities.

Implications for Managers

- Evaluate jobs, workgroups, and your organization to determine the optimal value, interest, and personality fit with employees.
- Consider screening job candidates for the personality traits that are most relevant to your organization's values (e.g., conscientiousness, extroversion) and the requirements most important for success in the job.
- Although many personality frameworks exist, there are striking differences in evidence and empirical support across measures. Based on these findings, managers should critically evaluate personality frameworks and the instruments used to measure them before making substantive decisions based on their results. We recommend the Big Five as this is the most widely supported personality framework to date.
- Although some personality traits are more suitable for predicting job performance while on the job, other personality traits can predict how well employees do in training and onboarding. Employees with certain traits may do better with additional support and guidance to prevent early turnover and contribute to their career development.
- Consider situational factors when evaluating observable personality traits. Policies, practices, and even events can make situations strong or weak or elicit the display of (un)desired personality traits. Attempt to modify the situation to encourage or dissuade certain behaviors, but recognize that this can sometimes have unintended effects.
- Although abilities are often the best predictors of job performance outside of proving that one can directly do the job, they tend to be wrought with disparate impact concerns. Exercise caution in assessing applicants and candidates for ability unless intellectual or physical abilities are necessary and required for the job.
- Resist the temptation to group coworkers and employees into generational categories—the evidence suggests that these differences are not very compelling. Furthermore, these generational categories can lead to harmful stereotyping and potentially to disparate impact or treatment toward employees from protected age classes.

Millennials Are More Narcissistic Than Other Generations

POINT

Millennials have some great virtues: As a group, they are technologically savvy, socially tolerant, and engaged. They value their quality of life as equal to their career, seeking a balance between home and work. In these ways, millennials surpass baby boomers, who are less technologically adept, less tolerant, and who have a history of striving to get ahead at all costs. However, millennials have a big Achilles' heel—they are more narcissistic.

Several large-scale, longitudinal studies found that millennials are more likely than baby boomers to have seemingly inflated views of themselves, and psychologists have found that narcissism has been growing since the early 1980s. More millennials rate themselves as above average on attributes such as academic ability, leadership, public speaking ability, and writing ability. Millennials are also more likely to agree they would be “very good” spouses (56 percent, compared to 37 percent among 1980 graduates), parents (54 percent; 36 percent for 1980 graduates), and workers (65 percent; 49 percent for 1980 graduates).

Cliff Zukin, a senior faculty fellow at Rutgers University, believes the reason is in the childhood upbringing of millennials. “This is the most affirmed generation in history,” Zukin said. “They were raised believing they could do anything they wanted to, and that they have skills and talents to bring to a job setting.” Jean M. Twenge, author of *Generation Me*, agrees. “People were not saying, ‘Believe in yourself’ and ‘You are special’ in the ‘60s.”

Narcissism is bad for society and particularly bad for the workplace. “[Narcissists] tend to be very self-absorbed; they value fun in their personal and their work life,” one administrator said. “I can’t expect them to work on one project for any amount of time without getting bored.”

COUNTERPOINT

Wasn’t “the Me Generation” generations ago? Honestly, every generation thinks they are better than the ones that come after! “You can find complaints [about the younger generation] in Greek literature, in the Bible,” Professor Cappelli of the Wharton School observed. “There’s no evidence Millennials are different. They’re just younger.” What is universally true is that young people share certain characteristics . . . *because* they are young.

A recent study shows the similarity between how millennials and baby boomers thought about themselves at the same stage of life. As college freshmen, 71 percent of millennials thought they were above average academically, and 63 percent of baby boomers thought the same thing when they were college freshmen. Similarly, 77 percent of millennials believed they were above average in the drive to achieve, versus 68 percent for baby boomers. In other words, “Every generation is Generation Me.”

In some ways, millennials may be less narcissistic than baby boomers today. As one manager observed, “[Millennials] don’t have that line between work and home that used to exist, so they’re doing Facebook for the company at night, on Saturday or Sunday. We get incredible productivity out of them.” Millennials also may be more altruistic. For example, 29 percent of millennials believe individuals have a responsibility to remain involved in issues and causes for the good of all, while only 24 percent of baby boomers feel the same level of responsibility.

Rather than comparing different generations, it is more accurate to compare people at one life stage with others at the same life stage. Research supports that younger people do tend to be more narcissistic than those in later life stages. Millennials are no more narcissistic than baby boomers were in their youth.²⁰⁰

CHAPTER REVIEW

QUESTIONS FOR REVIEW

5-1 What are the differences between person–job fit and person–organization fit?

5-2 What is personality? How do we typically measure it? What factors determine personality?

5-3 What are the strengths and weaknesses of the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI), the Big Five personality model, and the Dark Triad?

5-4 How do the concepts of core self-evaluation (CSE), self-monitoring, and proactive personality help us understand personality?

5-5 How does the situation affect the degree to which personality predicts behavior?

5-6 How are intellectual and physical abilities relevant to OB?

5-7 What is the difference between terminal and instrumental values?